dozen security force personnel injured in targeted attacks by militants and VDVs. Similarly, valley-based militants have targeted Assam Rifles personnel in Imphal and Thoubal.

Meitei civil society groups also allege that Kuki militants were behind the January 10 killing of four woodcutters on the border of Meitei-dominated Bishnupur and Kuki-dominated Churachandpur. Security sources corroborate their claim. "They were shot in the head with precision. That cannot be the work of a civilian," says a senior official of Assam Rifles. This incident, in fact, was the catalyst behind the Arambai Tenggol's summon to the legislators.

It's also one reason why the demand for the repeal of the SoO pact with Kuki militants has intensified. That agreement enjoined surrendered militants to stay confined to their designated camps. Meitei groups claim this provision has been violated regularly. For instance, two members of the Kuki Revolutionary Army (United), one of the outfits that was part of the SoO pact, were arrested in November for the kidnapping and murder of two Meitei boys.

ARAMBAI TENGGOL'S ACT OF BRAZENNESS INDICATES THE ABJECT SURRENDER OF THE STATE ADMINISTRATION

In this miasma of claims and counter-claims, there is one unambiguous truth the rise and acceptance of vigilante groups and the revival of militancy in Manipur point to: the failure of the governments, both at the Centre and in the state, to enforce the rule of law. Instead of finding a solution to the ethnic tension in the state, the administration has surrendered control to community organisations and insurgents. In fact, this marks a new kind of low. In the pursuit of parochial interests, the space for reconciliation and dialogue is shrinking every passing day. ■

WEST BENGAL

JUSTICE VERSUS JUSTICE

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar



SUBIR HALDER

SITE OF FRICTION The Calcutta High Court, (inset) Justice Abhijit Gangopadhyay

The Calcutta High Court was the site of recent judicial turbulence, forcing top judges of the Supreme Court to step in and restore some order. The row broke out when Justice Abhijit Gangopadhyay alleged that his brother judge, Justice Soumen Sen, was hand in glove with "some political party". On January 24, a single-judge bench of Justice Gangopadhyay had ordered a CBI probe into the alleged irregularities in the issuance of reserved category certificates and their use for admission in MBBS courses in medical colleges of West Bengal. A day later, the state government, through a verbal appeal, moved a division bench of Calcutta HC, comprising Justices Sen and Uday Kumar, and obtained an interim stay on Justice Gangopadhyay's order. With the division bench quashing an FIR registered by the CBI to probe the alleged admission scam, a riled Justice Gangopadhyay, who has earned a reputation for an avowed crusade against corruption, passed a counter order the same day, directing that the "CBI shall start investigation in this matter immediately". In the written order, he made the accusations against Justice Sen.

According to Justice Gangopadhyay's order, another judge, Justice